

“No one can make you feel inferior without your consent,” declared Eleanor Roosevelt in her 1937 memoir, *This is My Story*.¹ At the time, Roosevelt was not only the First Lady of the United States but also an advocate for civil and human rights. She has worked to ensure women’s rights in America by participating in the Women’s Trade Union League, later playing a major role in publishing the Universal Declaration of Human Rights.² During the 1930s in America, a period of economic hardship and entrenched social discrimination from the lingering effects of the Great Depression,³ her words offered psychological empowerment. Although women had suffrage, social discrimination still continued in the form of employment disparities.⁴ Racial segregation persisted in schools, workplaces, and public spaces.⁵ With this situation, Roosevelt’s statement was a call to resilience, encouraging people to realize their dignity came from themselves and affirm it against societal pressures that sought to define them.

At its core, the quote champions individual agency: that the feeling of inferiority is a choice, not a condition imposed from the outside. Though Roosevelt intended the quote to inspire self-empowerment, it is theoretically sound in terms of morals and ethics. However, the quote loses its universal applicability in reality due to external forces such as social norms, media influence, and modern conformity. This essay argues that while the feeling of inferiority requires internal consent in principle, the presence of powerful external influences often undermines this autonomy; thus, work is needed to realize Roosevelt’s quote so that a better society is built with individuals who recognize and preserve one’s dignity.

The feeling of inferiority must be distinguished from being objectively inferior. In any circumstance, a person may be objectively inferior to others, being shorter, slower, or less skilled than others in a given area.⁶ But, the emotional response of feeling inferior only results when the real or perceived deficiencies are internalized as a reflection of personal worth. This subjective reaction is not a direct consequence of the trait but a psychological interpretation done within one’s value system.⁷ For instance, a student with a poor test grade may feel inferior if they relate the test score with intelligence and self-worth. However, another student with the same test score might not develop the same feeling of inferiority as they do not relate the test score with personal values. This does not mean that people are encouraged to not relate their deficiencies to self-worth, but rather a simple example illustrating that the emotion of feeling inferior originates in the mind, contingent upon the meaning one assigns to a trait or experience.

From this perspective, Roosevelt’s quote holds theoretical validity. No one can impose feelings of inferiority unless one mentally grants personal significance to the perceived trait or an insult originating from the trait.⁷ Yet, it can be argued that people sometimes unconsciously develop feelings of inferiority. For some cases, the process of consciously giving consent to feel inferior about a characteristic by connecting to a value is omitted due to personal values being shaped by culture or background.⁸ Moreover, the feeling of inferiority is not completely responsible for the person developing such feelings. Nevertheless, even in such cases, it is indisputable that the

development of objective reality to subjective feeling was done with the contribution of one's mind. External insults or comparisons may trigger the response, but the feeling itself arises within the individual's mental framework.⁷ This internal processing implies a form of participation, whether voluntary or involuntary, signifying the idea that self-consent is involved.

However, the practical application of Roosevelt's claim is far more complicated. In many real-world situations, individuals are conditioned to feel inferior, incapable of exercising their consent through rational thinking due to external causes.⁹ Of course, the consent of an individual can still be executed consciously depending on the individual capacity of willpower, but most of the population will give consent involuntarily due to external circumstances. Furthermore, these situations are not including all individual interactions of insults or deficiencies, but rather a large-scale societal phenomenon of people feeling inferior. Regarding these phenomena, historical and social factors often plant the seeds of self-devaluation in ways that bypass critical self-awareness.

During Roosevelt's own time in the 1930s, America, her own country, still had deeply entrenched discriminatory societal norms. Although these discriminatory traditions especially targeting certain sexual or racial groups were alleviated than the past, laws and strong societal norms enforcing discrimination persisted.^{4 5} Even globally, discriminatory societal norms were common, such as countries lacking women suffrage or the Nazi Germany.^{10 11} During this period, specific groups targeted by discrimination were forced to give consent to feel inferior. This was possible as it was understood by the society that certain characteristics used to discriminate particular groups were connected to personal worth. The false relationship between the objective difference in characteristics, often portrayed as deficiencies or inferiority, with the personal worth of individuals was able to be achieved in most individuals' minds through societal norms.⁹ For instance, the relatively weaker body of women and skin color of African Americans were portrayed as a sign of inferiority in relation to personal worth of intelligence, leadership, and civility.^{12 13}

The societal norm of connecting different characteristics to inferiority and self worth was actively constructed and maintained through education and media.¹⁴ In many cases, societies informed people that certain characteristics are inferior through directly educating them or indirectly exposing them to the media. With education, it was taught that certain races were inferior to others, often citing social Darwinism as a validated reason.¹⁵ In the media, gender or race specific stereotyped roles were prevalent, like African Americans acting as servants or thieves, a role usually associated with low morals that can affect one's own value.¹⁶ These types of stereotypes created a social convention rooted deeply within everybody, granting consent upon individuals of specific groups to feel inferior regardless of their personal worth and what they value.¹⁷ In this historical context, Roosevelt's assertion becomes false regarding a societal scale of discrimination such as racism or sexism.

Contemporary society, despite its progress, unfortunately presents new challenges that weaken individual consent. Although societal discrimination of racism or sexism have been mitigated since the 1930s to the point that more individuals now have consent, which is shown through the change in societal norms in education and media to prohibit the connection racial or sexual characteristics to derogatory traits,¹⁸ other factors other than discrimination created external pressure to the point that consent is not applied. The main reason for this societal phenomenon is due to the increased effectiveness of conformity from the past due to quantifiable social approval, fear of missing out (FOMO), and fear of attacks on personal identity.

With the advent of social media and widespread supply of technology, social media is widely used.¹⁹ This does not only simply mean that conformity has gained more power from the past due to an increased number of people that have direct contact with an individual via social media. Beyond that, the meaning and importance of conformity was amplified. Before the widespread usage of social media, social approval was not easily quantifiable. Although there would have been occasions that showed one's social status through social approval such as invitations to occasions, it is hard to account for all of those events. However, as media that is interactable with individuals were developed, key features were often related to and reflected social approval amongst others. For example, followers or number of likes easily represent one's social status in their community. This quantification of social representation made people more easily influenced and aware of the external views of themselves.^{20 21}

Furthermore, the fear of missing out also increased with social media. People share their own life in social media, often leading to setting a certain standard on different aspects such as wealth or looks. For instance, everybody sharing their summer holiday trip to faraway countries can set a standard for summer vacations in terms of wealth, being a common and required expectation to have average wealth. As this standard is more visible than with the absence of social media, people are more likely to adapt to this standard, feeling excluded or inferior if they are under these standards regardless of its connection or significance to themselves.^{21 22}

Lastly, the fear of the backlash of presenting different views also increased. Through the media exposure to cancel culture,²³ including social "cancellations" of celebrities, people are increasingly being uncomfortable with sharing their views or perspectives. As different views from the mainstream opinion of the social group often leads to attacks on the identity of the person rather than their opinion, people are more reluctant to share or follow their own beliefs. All of these external factors pressure individuals to adapt and believe others' opinions or views rather than follow their own values, making them unconsciously accept every remark about them easily.²⁴ This works the same for the consent for insults, as individuals easily conform to insults to the point it gets prioritized over personal beliefs or identities.²⁵

Despite these realities, the correctness and insight of Roosevelt's quote remains powerful. If societies can foster environments where individuals are taught to critically evaluate external messages and value their own worth, then the capacity to resist internalizing inferiority can grow. This will build a better society in which people recognize their own power to preserve their dignity. Thus, actions to ensure the theoretical truth of Roosevelt's quote is required. Education becomes the most effective tool in this endeavor. Just as biased education once spread discriminatory norms, inclusive and thoughtful education can cultivate psychological resilience throughout the entire population.¹⁴ Teaching children about the nature of feeling inferior, the influence of media, and the importance of self definition of value can help maintain their autonomous consent giving to external conditions.

Although few curriculums of PSHE in the UK, CASEL in US, and IB worldwide exist that educates children regarding the matter of psychological resilience,²⁶ they often do not correctly impress the topic of self-worth enough with its importance. These curriculums are dependent on individual school's integration of their curriculums, leading to problems of shorter teaching time and uneducated teachers.²⁶ Schools often teach the topic shortly within a week or a day due to academic purposes, having short teaching time and deprived repetitions for the students to fully understand the topic. Teachers also are not fully aware of the importance nor meaning of the topic, causing lack of understanding in the students also.

In regards to current problems, for the new solution, curriculums should universally include teaching of the importance of self worth and how each individual should define their own values regardless of the influence of others. This should be done on a regular basis of about twenty minute classes per week with a strict guideline on the material taught by teachers educated on such topics. These curriculums will target young children who have not yet accessed social media, as that will easily impact the person's perception of personal value to the extent it is hardly adjustable.²⁷ Social media apps such as Instagram or Facebook grants account access from the age of 13,²⁸ suggesting that education should be received around elementary schoolers aged 5 to 10. This will enable students to provide consent for any insult towards them,¹⁴ creating better individuals with dignities that can build up a better society understanding different opinions.²⁴

Ultimately, Roosevelt's quote is not only an encouragement nor a factual claim but a philosophical ideal. While it may not be true in real world situations due to external forces existing in the past and present, it encourages individuals to fully acknowledge their dignity and self-worth to build a better society. Through education of the importance of personal value over external evaluation, Roosevelt's quote should be made true in reality, not only bringing theoretical truth to reality but also constructing a better society.

Endnotes

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